Sanen Kinsen Hiroku

Three Monkeys Gold Spring Secret Record

三猿金泉秘録

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A Secret Record on the Art of Rice Market Speculation

from the Edo Period of Japan

Source text attributed to
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Translated with AI assistance

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The complete methodology—including manuscript scans, character-by-character transcription, working translation files, and LaTeX source—is available at https://github.com/groverburger/sanen-kinsen-hiroku.

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About This Edition

This is the first English translation of the *Sanen Kinsen Hiroku*. The manuscript was sourced and the translation project directed by Zach Booth. The translation from classical Japanese was produced with AI assistance (Claude Opus 4.6, Anthropic), which read the original manuscript page images directly using multimodal capabilities. The original text is written in *kobun* (classical Japanese) with *kanbun kundoku* reading marks in cursive script (*kuzushiji*) on aged paper.

On Confidence. The translation was produced in two stages: first a character-by-character transcription of the Japanese with confidence levels, then an English translation from that transcription. The internal consistency of the text—where concepts introduced in the preface are operationalized in the trading rules, quantified in the calculation tables, and synthesized in the grand diagram—provides confidence that the overall structure and teachings are accurately captured. Individual prose passages, particularly in dense cursive sections, may reflect close paraphrase rather than word-for-word fidelity. Uncertain readings are noted throughout.

How to Read This Translation

The body text of this book is a direct translation of the source manuscript. The chapter and section headings are editorial, added for navigation. Footnotes marked "*Translator's note*" provide historical context, definitions, and comparative observations. Rare indented passages marked "*Editor's note*" provide brief editorial bridges where the manuscript's structure requires explanation. Chapter lengths vary because the translation follows the manuscript's own proportions—some topics receive extensive treatment in the source, others only a line or two. Everything else is Ushida's words.

Structure of the Text. Chapters 1–2 establish the cosmological framework and seasonal trading rules. Chapters 3–4 present the mechanics of staged entry and the sixty-year weather cycle. Chapters 5–8 build the decision framework: market forces, the four virtues, the Middle Star mean-reversion system, and the Seven Fortunes. Chapter 9 synthesizes everything in the Grand Diagram. Chapters 10–11 close with sentiment-reading and final teachings.

Contents

Translator's Introduction **8**

1 Preface: The Cosmology of the Market **10**

2 Favorable and Adverse Conditions; The Articles of Trading **11**
2.1 Favorable and Adverse Conditions 11
2.2 The Fifteen Articles of Trading 12
2.3 The Thirty-Eight Provisions for Seasonal Trading 13

3 The Record of Patterns and Staged Entry **15**
3.1 Record of Spike Patterns 15
3.2 The Tree Diagrams 16
3.3 The Turnover Method 17

4 The Sixty-Year Cycle: Weather, Tides, and Harvest **19**
4.1 Violent Storms 19
4.2 Floods 19
4.3 Frost and Cold 20
4.4 Bountiful Harvest Years 20
4.5 The Plum Rains 20
4.6 Tides 20
4.7 Wind 20

5 The Eight Poles, Celestial Signs, and the Six Observations **21**
5.1 The Eight Poles 21
5.1.1 The Force of One-Nine (一旅将壱九之勢) 21
5.2 Celestial Anomalies 21
5.3 The Six Observations 22

6 The Four Virtues of the Trader **23**
6.1 Benevolence (仁, *Jin*) 23
6.1.1 On Upper, Middle, and Lower Positions 23
6.2 Wisdom (智, *Chi*) 24
6.2.1 The Standard of Calm Profit (平楽定式) 24
6.2.2 Regional Market Timing 24
6.3 Courage (勇, *Yū*) 24
6.4 Discipline (節, *Setsu*) 25

7 The Three Levels and the Middle Star **26**
7.1 The Three Levels 26
7.2 The Middle Star 26
7.2.1 Secret Tradition of Bullish Positioning (強氣立の秘傳) 28
7.3 Position Calculations at the Middle Star 28
7.3.1 The Way of Favorable Conditions (順道) 28
7.3.2 Trading with 100 Ryō 29
7.3.3 Scaling the Method: 200 to 1,000 Ryō 29
7.3.4 The Method of Calculating Half-Board Rice Sales . 30

8 The Seven Fortunes Secret; Following Gold **31**
8.1 The Seven Conditions 31
8.2 On Patience and Money 31
8.3 Following Gold 32

9 The Grand Diagram **33**
9.1 How to Read the Diagram 33
9.1.1 Comprehensive Measurement (度諸) 33
9.1.2 The Structure 33
9.1.3 Applying the Diagram 35

10 Reading Strong and Weak Qi **36**
10.1 The Beginning of Strong Qi 36
10.2 The Beginning of Weak Qi 36
10.3 The Great First Decline 36
10.4 Wind and Rain 36

11 Regional Markets and Final Teachings **38**
11.1 The Geography of Information 38
11.2 The World's Accumulation (世の中積り之事) 38

Select Bibliography **40**

Glossary of Key Terms **42**

About the Editor **44**

A Position Calculation Tables **45**
A.1 Trading with 200 Ryō (二百両買) 45
A.2 Trading with 300 Ryō (三百両買) 45
A.3 Trading with 500 Ryō (五百両買) 46
A.4 Scaling to 1,000 Ryō (千両) 46

Translator's Introduction

The *Sanen Kinsen Hiroku* (三猿金泉秘録), or "Three Monkeys Gold Spring Secret Record," is one of the most celebrated texts in the history of Japanese market speculation.[1]

The title alludes to the proverb of the three monkeys—"see no evil, hear no evil, speak no evil" (見ざる、聞かざる、言わざる)—reinterpreted as a warning to the trader: do not be swayed by what you *see* others doing, what you *hear* as rumor, or what you *say* in haste. Instead, observe the deeper patterns.

Authorship and the Edo Rice Market

The manuscript names its author as Ushida Gonzaburō (牛田権三郎), an Osaka Dōjima trader from Ise province who wrote under the pen name Jiunsai (慈雲斎). The text was composed around 1755 and later revised and corrected by Narukawa Takenosuke (鳴川猛之助). It belongs to a genre of "secret market transmission texts" (相場秘伝書, *sōba hidensho*) that circulated among Edo-period trading houses.[2]

During the Tokugawa period (1603–1868), rice was the basis of the economy. The Dōjima Rice Exchange (堂島米会所) in Osaka functioned as a sophisticated futures market where "book rice" (帳合米) was traded as forward contracts.[3]

A Note on Attribution

English-language sources almost universally attribute this text to Honma Munehisa (本間宗久) of Sakata, often under the title "The Fountain of Gold—The Three Monkey Record of Money." This attribution is incorrect.

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[1] *Translator's note:* The manuscript is dated 嘉永四年五月廿日 (1851) and identifies itself as a copy of the Kōmondō (好問堂) edition, published at Igarashi-tsu (五十嵐津). The text references the Tenmei era (1781–1789) extensively for its price data.

[2] *Translator's note:* The inner title page of the manuscript also bears the label 三猿軍書選 (*Sanen gunsho sen*, "Selection from the Three Monkeys Military/Strategy Books"), framing the text within a tradition that explicitly borrows the language of military strategy for market speculation.

[3] *Translator's note:* The Dōjima Rice Exchange was established in 1697 as a spot market. Organized futures trading (帳合米) was formally authorized by the shogunate in 1730, making it one of the world's first organized futures markets.

The manuscript names its author as Ushida Gonzaburō and its editor as Narukawa Takenosuke—as do the National Diet Library catalog, the CiNii bibliographic record, and every Japanese-language reference work that discusses it. In Japanese scholarship, this is not controversial: the NDL, CiNii, Kyoto University's digital archive, and sources from Honma's own hometown (the Shonai Securities company of Sakata) all attribute the *Sanen Kinsen Hiroku* to Ushida.

Honma Munehisa was a real historical figure—a Sakata trader who was expelled from his own family for speculating with company capital and who became legendary in his own right. Texts were later attributed to him (the *Sōkyū-ō Hiroku* and *Sōba Sanmai-den*), though no Edo-period originals of these survive; Japanese scholars suspect they were compiled in the Meiji era. Honma's texts have entirely different titles and contents from Ushida's.

The confusion appears to have entered English through Steve Nison's influential *Japanese Candlestick Charting Techniques* (1991), a book that did enormous service in introducing Japanese technical analysis to Western traders. In synthesizing a large body of Japanese-language material for an English-speaking audience, Nison consolidated several distinct figures and texts into a single narrative—an understandable simplification given the complexity of the source tradition. Nison himself corrected the record in *Beyond Candlesticks* (1994, p. 14), writing that his research indicated Honma "likely did not use candlestick charts." But the first book reached millions of readers, and the broader conflation of names and titles took on a life of its own.

In the decades since, English sources have merged Ushida's title with Honma's name, creating a phantom text: "The Fountain of Gold" (金泉) and "Three Monkeys" (三猿) are both from Ushida's title; the Honma texts have completely different names. Two English-language books have been published under variations of this text's title. Neither translates it. Both render a separate body of trading maxims from the Honma/Sakata tradition—a related but distinct lineage—while putting Ushida's title on the cover.

What follows is, to my knowledge, the first English translation of the actual *Sanen Kinsen Hiroku*, made directly from the 1851 manuscript held at Kyoto University.

—Zach Booth

Chapter 1

Preface: The Cosmology of the Market

三猿金泉録序

Preface to the Three Monkeys Gold Spring Record

THE SUPREME ULTIMATE[1] moves and gives birth to Yang; when still, it gives birth to Yin. The principle of one stillness and one movement—Heaven and Earth rise and fall according to this logic. Movement reaches its extreme and becomes stillness; stillness reaches its extreme and becomes movement again. Movement and stillness are the root of one another.

This is the principle by which strong qi[2] and weak qi alternate.

When this principle is applied to all things, there is nothing it does not encompass. When applied to rice, the qi of people—whether strong or weak—is contained within this principle. Those who combine this understanding with close observation of the market will find it reasonable. In years of good harvests and times of fine weather, one should compare and examine the rice markets.

This is the principle that transcends mere natural disposition.

In recent years, new rice arriving in the ninth and tenth months has been declining in price. When rice falls, strong buying emerges—this is the buying pattern. Conversely, when rice has been rising for some months, selling pressure appears at the ceiling.

Within a cycle of favorable and adverse conditions spanning twelve or thirteen years, the secret records of the house—the family tradition of profitable trading arts spanning thirty generations—through the miraculous art of accumulating wealth with a capital of fifteen thousand ryō across ten degrees of trading, are secretly stored. This is the family tradition of Ushida Gonzaburō.

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[1] *Translator's note:* 太極 (*taikyoku*). The foundational concept of Neo-Confucian cosmology. The opening echoes Zhou Dunyi's *Taijitu shuo* (Explanation of the Diagram of the Supreme Ultimate, mid-11th century), grounding market theory in the highest philosophical authority.

[2] *Translator's note:* 強気 (*tsuyoki*), literally "strong spirit"—bullish sentiment. Its opposite, 弱気 (*yowaki*), "weak spirit," is bearish sentiment.

Chapter 2

Favorable and Adverse Conditions; The Articles of Trading

2.1 Favorable and Adverse Conditions

順来・逢来 — *Junrai and Airai*

> *Editor's note:* Two units recur throughout the text that follows. 両 (*ryō*): the standard gold coin of the Edo period, used here as the unit of trading capital. 俵 (*tawara*): a bale of rice, the standard unit of measure for rice trading and price quotation. Gold and rice—ryō and tawara—are the two axes of every calculation in this text.

The market moves in great cycles of favorable conditions (順来 (*junrai*)) and adverse conditions (逢来 (*airai*)). Within a period of roughly twelve to thirteen years, favorable conditions persist for approximately ten years, and adverse conditions for three.[1]

During favorable years, rice is generally at high levels. When old rice (古米 (*komai*))[2] is in a year of abundance, it will be cheap. Buy in the fourth month. By mid-sixth month, prices will be high—this is where one sells. In autumn, buy again around the seventh month. Toward year-end, the price of old rice will rise, and one should sell again.

This is the fundamental pattern of favorable years.

In adverse years, the cheap period for old rice falls around the fourth through sixth months. In autumn, one should buy, and by year-end the rice price climbs.

[1] *Translator's note:* This roughly 10:3 ratio of bull-to-bear years anticipates modern observations about market asymmetry—that markets spend more time rising than falling, but that the falls are sharper.

[2] *Translator's note:* Rice from previous harvests, as opposed to 新米 (*shinmai*), newly harvested rice. Old rice was traded as a distinct commodity.

A song (歌, *uta*) on favorable conditions for the four seasons, and the estimation of highs and lows:[3]

> In a year of favorable conditions,
> the autumn harvest is plentiful;
> the highs and lows can be estimated
> across four seasons.
>
> In spring, from around the fourth month onward,
> buy at the fifth-month level;
> by the end of the year,
> the high price will come.

In favorable periods, the rice market's sentiment (人気 (*jinki*))[4] for each month can be read directly. The fifth-month and year-end levels become the reference points. In a year of great flood, the rice market reacts through the twelfth month.

2.2 The Fifteen Articles of Trading

十五ヶ条 禁物場 — *Jūgo Kajō, Kinmotsu-ba*
Fifteen Articles: Forbidden Things of the Marketplace

[5]

Within the market, one must read the sentiment of the crowd—whether people are inclined to buy or sell—and not act rashly.

禁判: The large trader may think that because he has capital, he can afford to hold a losing position. This is a grave error. Even with great capital, if one buys recklessly and the market moves against him, the losses compound. Conversely, a trader of modest means who reads the market well and trades with discipline can accumulate wealth steadily.

---

[3] *Translator's note:* The source text identifies this passage as an *uta*—a verse or mnemonic poem, a common device in Edo-period instructional texts for making key principles memorable.

[4] *Translator's note:* Literally "people-qi"—the collective mood of market participants.

[5] *Translator's note:* The section heading names fifteen articles, but the manuscript presents them as flowing prose punctuated by cautionary markers (禁判, *kinban*, literally "forbidden judgment") rather than as a numbered list. Approximately six to eight distinct 禁判 markers are legible in the cursive script. Whether the remaining articles were lost in transmission, are embedded in the prose without explicit markers, or whether "fifteen" is a conventional number for such collections is unclear from this manuscript. What follows is a faithful translation of the legible text.

禁判: The decision to buy or sell should not be made lightly. One should observe for several days. When the rice price has been falling and reaches a point where it no longer declines despite bad news—this is the moment to buy. When rice has been rising and ceases to advance despite favorable reports—this is the moment to sell.

禁判: Do not follow the crowd blindly. When all are buying, consider selling; when all are selling, consider buying. The profit lies in going against common sentiment, yet one must have sound reason for doing so.[6]

禁判: Those who deal in large quantities and those with small capital must both observe these rules equally. The method is the same for all.

禁判: In the autumn months, when new rice enters the market and the old rice price adjusts, the trading of the fourth month must be read carefully. In times of uncertainty, do not commit fully.

禁判: When the people of the world (世の人) are of one mind regarding the market, the strong and weak sentiments must be weighed. One should consider whether the rice has reached a level where the movement must reverse.

> *Editor's note:* Several further 禁判 markers are present in the manuscript but the surrounding cursive text is too damaged or faded to translate with confidence.

2.3 The Thirty-Eight Provisions for Seasonal Trading

三十八ヶ条 商内 — *Sanjūhachi Kajō, Shōnai*
Thirty-Eight Provisions for Trading

[7]

In a year of adverse conditions (逢来), from around the fifth month onward, summer rice drops and autumn months see further decline. Autumn months are for buying; favorable months are for the pattern of waiting.

[6] *Translator's note:* This contrarian principle predates the Western maxim "buy when there is blood in the streets" (apocryphally attributed to Baron Rothschild, first documented in print in the 1890s).

[7] *Translator's note:* As with the Fifteen Articles, the heading names thirty-eight provisions, but the manuscript presents them as continuous prose about seasonal trading rather than a numbered enumeration. The provisions are woven into the narrative of monthly and seasonal patterns. Whether a fully enumerated version existed in another recension of the text is unknown.

In a year of good harvest (上作 (*jōsaku*)), rice is abundant and prices are depressed.[8] In an average harvest (中作 (*chūsaku*)), prices fall between the extremes. In a poor harvest (下作 (*gesaku*)), rice is scarce and prices rise.

In a year of favorable conditions, from spring onward: if the harvest is expected to be plentiful, summer rice will be cheap. Buy in the third or fourth month at the low, and sell by the middle of the sixth month when the price has risen.

In autumn, buy again at the harvest-month low. By year-end, old rice prices climb, and this is where one takes profit.

In an adverse year, the pattern reverses. From the fifth month, prices decline through summer. The autumn months—seventh, eighth, ninth—are the buying months. By the year-end, prices recover.

For the months from the tenth onward, consider the first ten days of each month. The market's movement can be read within each four-to-five month period.

In the fifth month, in a year of poor harvest, the rice situation becomes tight; one should buy at the lower level. But in a strong-yield period of four years, the rice pattern reverses.

The sentiment of the rice market (米來人気筋) can be read directly from the monthly price action. The favorable-condition months and the adverse-condition months each have their own character. The trader who reads them alongside the harvest forecast can establish the full year's plan.

When weak qi pervades the world and things seem to continue weakening, yet the rice price is at a level that appears flat—this is the year of rice buying. The flat price amid universal pessimism signals that the selling is exhausted. What cannot fall further must eventually rise.

[8] *Translator's note:* 上作/中作/下作 refer to harvest quality grades—good, average, and poor. 上作 (literally "upper crop") is an abundant harvest; 下作 ("lower crop") is a poor one.

Chapter 3

The Record of Patterns and Staged Entry

3.1 Record of Spike Patterns

穂足の録 — *Hosoku no Roku*

> *Editor's note:* 穂足 (*hosoku*): literally "grain-spike form"—穂 (ear of rice) plus 足 (form/trace). In modern Japanese trading, 足 is the standard suffix for price representations: ローソク足 (candlestick), 日足 (daily bar), かぎ足 (hook chart), etc. Whether 穂足 is an early instance of this convention is an open question—Edo-period traders used bar charts (棒足) and anchor charts (いかり足) rather than candlesticks, which are a Meiji-era development. But the shared 足 suffix and the agricultural metaphor (an ear of rice is morphologically similar to a candlestick element) are suggestive. No scholar appears to have previously noted this term.

When buying and holding, one must consider the fortune (運 (*un*)) and the momentum (気 (*ki*)). The transport and supply dynamics, whether two hundred days or three hundred days, the seasonal movements and annual patterns must be compared.

One should not be impatient: observe for two or three days, then when the rice begins to move, buy. Those who buy impulsively and hold stubbornly will fail. Gold and rice are like flowing water; one must read them well, buy carefully, and sell at the right moment.

3.2 The Tree Diagrams

萬光商内之圖
Bankō Shōnai no Zu — Diagram of Ten-Thousand-Light Trading

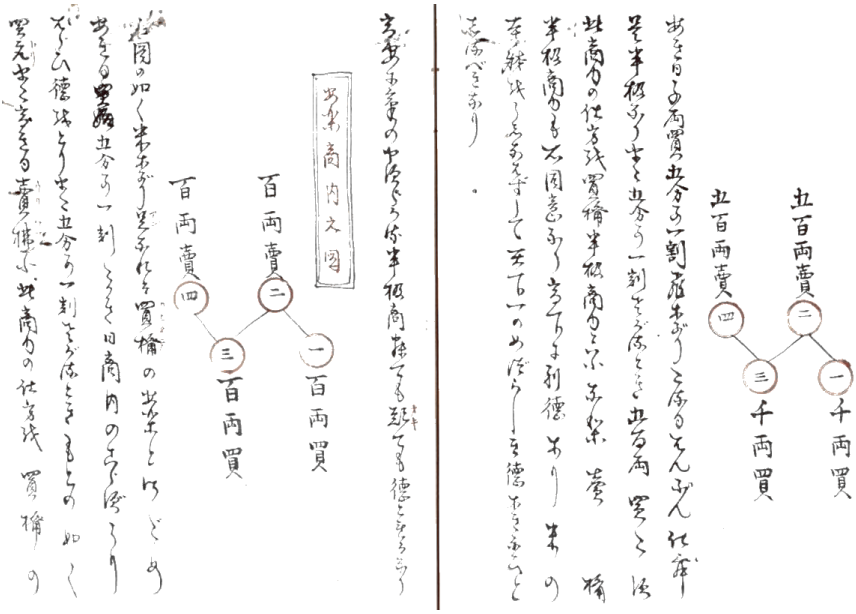

Figure 3.1: Position-scaling tree diagrams from the original manuscript. Right page: building from a base purchase (千十両買)[2] through four stages to a 500-ryō position (五百両買). Left page: the 100-ryō sell diagram (百両売) and the turnover method (転愛商内之圖), showing how a 1,000-ryō buying position scales to a 2,000-ryō selling position. *Image: Kyoto University Main Library.*

The secret of profitable trading lies not in any single transaction but in the method of building and unwinding positions through stages.

Starting from a base purchase, build the position through numbered stages. Stage One (壱): the initial commitment of capital—a small, probing entry that tests the market's direction. Stage Two (弐): when the direction is confirmed, a larger addition. Stage Three (参): further addition as confidence grows. Stage Four (四): the position reaches its full size.

The same principle applies in reverse when selling: do not liquidate the entire position at once but sell in stages, observing the market's reaction at each step.

3.3 The Turnover Method

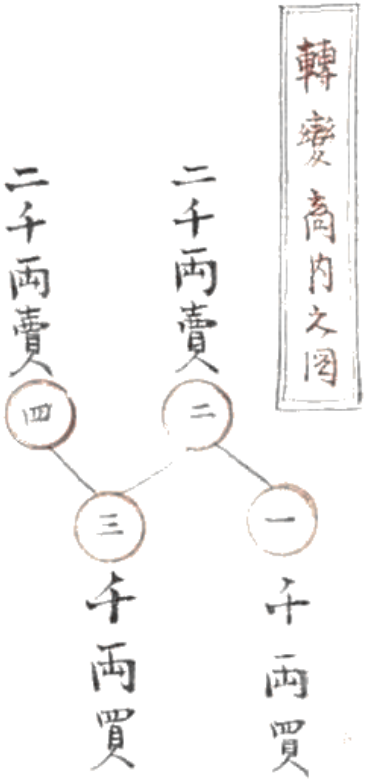

Figure 3.2: The turnover diagram (転愛商内之圖[4], *Diagram of Revolving Trading*). A 1,000-ryō buying position (千両買, bottom) scales through four stages (壱–四) to a 2,000-ryō selling position (二千両売, top). *Image: Kyoto University Main Library.*

[4]The diagram's title cartouche reads 転愛商内之圖. The body text uses 転換の法 (*tenkan no hō*, "turnover method") for the same concept. The character 愛 in the title may be a variant or cursive form of 換; both readings are preserved as they appear in the manuscript.

When buying positions reach their target, begin to build selling positions simultaneously—this is the turnover method (転換の法 (*tenkan no hō*)). For every 1,000 ryō in buying positions, prepare to sell 2,000 ryō worth. As the market reaches its peak, the momentum of the crowd drives prices beyond fair value. The disciplined trader sells more than he bought, profiting from the overshoot.

When traders buy at low prices and see profits growing, they become greedy and wish to hold longer. When they see losses, they become fearful and wish to sell at once. Both impulses are the enemy of profit. The disciplined trader sells when he wishes to hold, and holds when he wishes to sell—going against his own emotions as well as those of the crowd.

This art is not to be shared lightly. It is passed down within the family and among trusted associates only.

Chapter 4

The Sixty-Year Cycle: Weather, Tides, and Harvest

暴風 運気豊凶之録
Record of Storms, Fortune-Qi, and Abundance or Famine

A twelve-year sub-cycle governs the alternation of fortune and misfortune in harvests. Two hundred and thirty years of records were consulted, tracking patterns of weather and their correlation with the sexagenary cycle (干支 (*kanshi*)).

> *Editor's note:* The years in this chapter are named using the sexagenary cycle, which pairs one of ten Heavenly Stems (甲乙丙丁戊己庚辛壬癸) with one of twelve Earthly Branches (子丑寅卯辰巳午未申酉戌亥). The combinations produce a sixty-year cycle before repeating. Each year has a unique two-character name: 甲子 (*kinoe-ne*) is year 1, 乙丑 (*kinoto-ushi*) is year 2, and so on through all sixty. As a rough guide to Western dates: 甲子 corresponds to 1744, 1804, and 1864; each designation recurs every sixty years.

4.1 Violent Storms

In certain years, violent storms and market surges are more frequent: 甲子 (1), 丁卯 (4), 丁未 (44), 甲戌 (11), 甲申 (21), 辛卯 (28), 甲午 (31).[1] In these years, rice markets experience extreme volatility; prices may surge two or three times within a single season.

4.2 Floods

Years containing 己 (*tsuchinoto*) in their stem are associated with water disasters: 己巳 (6), 己卯 (16), 己丑 (26), 己亥 (36), 己酉 (46), 己未 (56). These bring three-year periods of disruption.

[1] *Translator's note:* The numbers in parentheses indicate the year's position within the sixty-year cycle.

4.3 Frost and Cold

Unusual cold damages crops: 己巳 (6), 己亥 (36), 己未 (56). These trigger three-year adverse periods. Rice prices rise sharply.

4.4 Bountiful Harvest Years

Years of bountiful harvest (豊作 (*hōsaku*)) were tracked across twenty-eight years of records and correlated with the sexagenary cycle. In autumn months, yields were logged, producing a predictive framework spanning the full sixty-year cycle.

4.5 The Plum Rains

The onset of the plum rain season (梅雨 (*tsuyu*)) follows an approximately eight-year sub-cycle. Early plum rains generally indicate good harvests. Late plum rains may indicate drought followed by flooding.

Associated years: 丙寅 (3), 丙子 (13), 庚辰 (17), 庚寅 (27), 壬午 (19), 壬辰 (29), 丙申 (33), 丙午 (43).

4.6 Tides

大潮小潮之差 — *The Difference Between Spring and Neap Tides*

The patterns of spring tides (大潮 (*ōshio*)—the large tides at new and full moon) and neap tides (小潮 (*koshio*)—the small tides at quarter moon) bear on weather prediction. In years of great tidal difference, storms are more likely. The timing of tides in relation to planting and harvesting seasons provides further indicators.

4.7 Wind

Wind direction and timing follow their own cycles: 戊申 (45), 己卯 (16), 丙辰 (53), 丁巳 (54), 庚申 (57). In years of strong autumn wind, harvest damage increases. The period between the seventh and ninth months is critical.

A ten-year or fifteen-year span governs the wind's major directional shifts. Across one hundred years of observation, these cycles hold with reasonable reliability—roughly one year of error in every ten.

Chapter 5

The Eight Poles, Celestial Signs, and the Six Observations

5.1 The Eight Poles

八極 三千目 — *Eight Poles, Three Thousand Points*

The categories of market force: Yang (陽)—the bullish, rising force. Yin (陰)—the bearish, falling force. The Supreme Ultimate (太極)—equilibrium. Yin convergence (陰合)—multiple bearish factors aligning at once.

5.1.1 The Force of One-Nine (一旅将壱九之勢)

Just as a general must commit his forces decisively at the right moment, the trader must commit capital when the signs align. Hesitation at the critical moment means the opportunity passes.

When ten thousand people are all of one mind—all buying or all selling—the reversal is near. A thousand people of the same opinion is a strong signal. Ten thousand unanimous is an extreme. At such moments, the solitary trader who goes against them has the advantage.

5.2 Celestial Anomalies

天怪 — *Tenkai*

When extraordinary signs appear—unusual weather, disruptions to the normal seasonal flow—first determine whether these are temporary or lasting in their effect. The ordinary rice price level is established over a year, and only deviations from this level are traded.

5.3 The Six Observations

六秘見 — *Roku Hiken*

When watching the rice market, first observe these six things:[1]

1. The 20% level (二割 (*ni-wari*)): if rice falls 20% from its high, this is a meaningful correction.
2. The 30% level (三割 (*san-wari*)): a major correction inviting careful buying.
3. Within the high range (高の内 (*taka no uchi*)): movements here are distribution, not accumulation.
4. Sideways movement (横の平 (*yoko no hira*)): the market is undecided; wait.
5. People's sentiment (人の気 (*hito no ki*)): the crowd's mood as a contrary indicator.
6. The grand trend (大勢 (*taisei*)): the overarching direction that governs all shorter movements.

These six observations determine all trading. When wishing to buy, first check whether the price has already risen 20–30% from its base. If it has, the opportunity for buying has passed; wait for the next decline.

All buying and selling should be done proportionally. When buying, think of mountains—rice is like mountains and water; it naturally rises and falls. The great mountain does not rise in a day, and neither does the great price movement. Buy in portions: first a small amount, then add as the direction confirms.

When a thousand people are of one mind regarding the market, and a single trader perceives something different, he must weigh his own observation against the crowd's. If his reasoning is sound and based on the six observations, he may be right even against one thousand.

[1] *Translator's note:* These six observations form a structured checklist—essentially a pre-trade evaluation framework.

Chapter 6

The Four Virtues of the Trader

6.1 Benevolence (仁, *Jin*)

Buy once, and it returns to its original level. Wait.[1][2]

When one buys and the price immediately returns to the purchase level, do not panic and sell at cost. The market is testing the trader's resolve. This is the test of benevolence—patience and compassion for one's own position.

If after buying, the price falls and then recovers to near the purchase price, this pattern—repeated over three years—teaches the trader to endure. In each of those years, the rice that was bought at what seemed a bad time eventually proved profitable for those who held.

6.1.1 On Upper, Middle, and Lower Positions

At the upper level (上位 (*jōi*)), rice has risen strongly and is at the top of its range. One should be selling, not buying. At the middle level (中位 (*chūi*)), rice is at its ordinary seasonal level; wait and observe. At the lower level (下位 (*gei*)), rice has fallen to the bottom of its range. This is where buying begins.

When the price has been at a low level for three hundred days or more, and a rise begins, and then the price returns and falls again to a new low—this is the final bottom. Buy here.

---

[1] *Translator's note:* The source text names four virtues: Benevolence (仁), Wisdom (智), Courage (勇), and Discipline (節). The traditional Confucian system names five constant virtues (五常), the fifth being Trustworthiness (信, *shin*). Whether the fifth was omitted deliberately or lost in transmission is unknown from this manuscript.

[2] *Translator's note:* The manuscript heading for this section reads 仁 — 壱首・壱百五拾目 (*Jin — Isshu, hyaku gojū me*), meaning "Benevolence—First article; the 150th item." This reference to 150 is unexplained and may indicate the text draws from a larger collection of trading rules.

6.2 Wisdom (智, *Chi*)

Wisdom in trading has ten aspects:[3] knowing when to enter, knowing when to exit, reading the mood of the market, understanding seasonal patterns, and patience in waiting for the right moment.

6.2.1 The Standard of Calm Profit (平楽定式)

Buying is done at a set price level; one then holds until the target selling month. This requires patience: one must not sell early when prices dip temporarily, nor hold past the target when greed urges more.

6.2.2 Regional Market Timing

The relationship between different regional markets—Dōjima, Bakan, and others—creates timing advantages. Information flows between them with delay. The timing gap between regional price movements creates opportunities for the informed trader. The trader who understands this flow profits from the gap.

When favorable conditions turn and the market reverses, the signs are subtle at first. The price may stop rising for several days; then a slight decline sets in. Those who recognize this early transition profit the most.

6.3 Courage (勇, *Yū*)

The courage to act when the signs align, even when the crowd moves in the opposite direction. Courage without wisdom is recklessness; wisdom without courage is paralysis.[4]

[3] *Translator's note:* The source text states "ten principles" (十) for this virtue, though the prose that follows does not enumerate all ten individually.

[4] *Translator's note:* The manuscript's treatment of this virtue is very brief; the phrasing here is interpretive.

6.4 Discipline (節, *Setsu*)

Following the method even when emotions urge otherwise. The cautious man who holds 陸金 (*rikukin*)[5] of twenty tawara and trades with five will survive all storms. He who trades with his entire fortune will eventually be ruined.

[5] *Translator's note:* 陸金 literally "land gold"—stable reserves kept out of the market, as opposed to capital actively deployed in trading positions. This passage appears in the manuscript within the "Following Gold" (随金) section (page 27); it is placed here under "Discipline" because it states the virtue's core principle.

Chapter 7

The Three Levels and the Middle Star

The total yields (諸高) of all rice-producing domains, combined: 28,548 *chō*,[1] comprising 9,484,815 *tawara* in autumn harvest estimates.

世の中 三段之圖
Diagram of the Three Levels of the World

7.1 The Three Levels

The rice market at any moment exists within one of three supply ranges.[2] The upper supply level (上): approximately 35 tawara—rice is abundant, prices are at their floor (底直); this is where buying is indicated. The middle level (中): approximately 30 tawara, 1 bu—equilibrium, where one observes and waits. The lower supply level (下): approximately 25 tawara—rice is scarce, prices are at their ceiling (天井); this is where selling is indicated.

7.2 The Middle Star

The 中星 (*chūboshi*), or "Middle Star," is the central concept. Across thirty years of observation, the average rice price establishes a central equilibrium.[3]

When price is at the middle star: observe and wait. When price falls to twenty percent below the middle star: begin buying. When price rises to twenty percent above the middle star: begin selling.

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[1] *Translator's note:* 町 (*chō*), a unit of land area approximately equal to 2.45 acres or 1 hectare. The figure represents the total productive rice land across all domains, used to calculate the autumn harvest estimate.

[2] *Translator's note:* The tawara figures here measure rice *supply*, not price. The relationship to price is inverse: when supply is high (35 tawara), rice is abundant and prices are low; when supply is low (25 tawara), rice is scarce and prices are high. Thus 天井 (*tenjō*, price ceiling—the highest price point) corresponds to the *lowest* supply level (25 tawara), and 底直 (*soko-ne*, price floor—the lowest price point) corresponds to the *highest* supply level (35 tawara).

[3] *Translator's note:* This is essentially a moving average concept. The principle—trading deviations from a long-term mean—is the foundation of modern mean-reversion strategies.

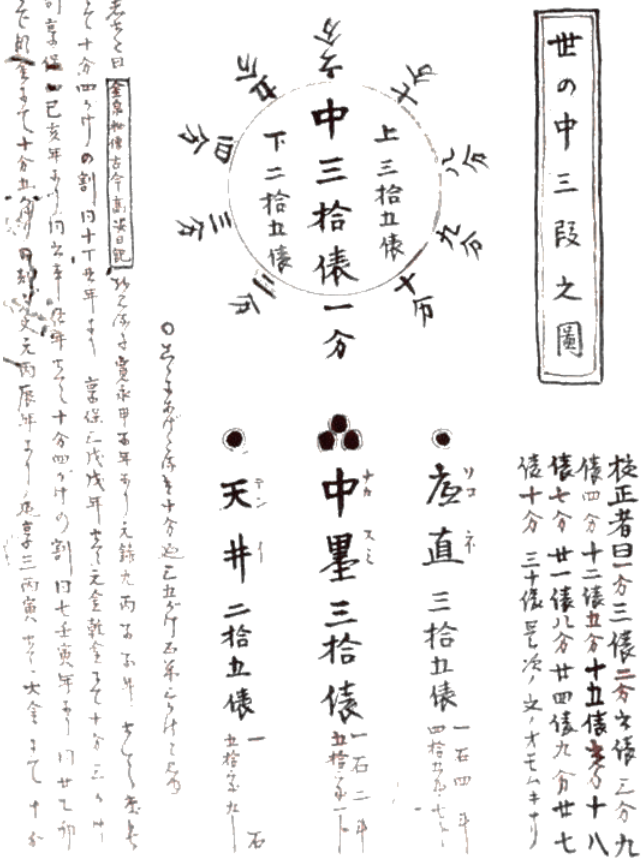

Figure 7.1: The Three Levels Diagram (世の中三段之圖). The circle is divided into Upper (上, 35 tawara supply), Middle (中, 30 tawara), and Lower (下, 25 tawara supply). Below: the Ceiling (天井, price peak at lowest supply), Floor (底直, price trough at highest supply), and Middle Star (中星, equilibrium) reference points with their associated calculation tables. *Image: Kyoto University Main Library.*

7.2.1 Secret Tradition of Bullish Positioning (強氣立の秘傳)

The secret method for establishing bullish positions: at 400–800 ryō, begin with staged entries. At 20% below the middle star: the first entry. At 30% below: the second entry, larger. The total position should never exceed what can be held for one full year.

When new rice arrives cheaply but the middle star indicates the underlying trend is upward, the new rice represents a buying opportunity.

In a year of abundant harvest, the direct price falls to the middle star or below. Buy at this point and hold, as in subsequent years the price will revert.

7.3 Position Calculations at the Middle Star

The source text devotes approximately six pages to detailed numerical tables showing staged position-building at the middle star level.[4] The method is demonstrated at multiple capital levels, always following the same proportional discipline: never commit the full position at once, and reinvest profits at each stage to compound returns.

An important distinction for reading these tables: the percentage figures (一割, 二割, 三割—10%, 20%, 30%) refer to the *market's price movement* from the middle star level, not to returns on capital. That is, "at 10%" means "when the price has moved 10% from the middle star, enter the position." These are entry triggers, not profit targets.

7.3.1 The Way of Favorable Conditions (順道)

In the Tenmei era, within the market: old rice is bought beginning in the third or fourth month, at a level of 130 [units]. Buying at 20 tawara positions, adjusting at each stage. The buying and selling compounds across four months. Positions are built across 17–18 stages, with the running total reaching 200+ ryō through methodical trading of 500–800 bale positions. This is the family tradition (家傳), twelfth month, 100 ryō within the market.

[4] *Translator's note:* In these tables, capital is measured in 両 (*ryō*, gold coins) and rice positions in 俵 (*tawara*, bales). The method at each capital level follows the same structure: an initial entry at 10% (一割) of capital, then successive additions at 20% (二割) as the market confirms direction, with profits reinvested at each stage to compound the position. The "middle star level" (中星世俵) is the reference price at which all entries are made. Some of the specific figures in the manuscript are difficult to read with certainty due to the cursive script; uncertain readings are bracketed.

7.3.2 Trading with 100 Ryō

百両売 天之商内 — *100 Ryō Sell, Within Heaven's Trading*

Starting from a base of 100 ryō at the middle star (中星世俵) level, using Osaka market rates (大坂数位):[5]

壱: 100 ryō committed, 20 tawara at the middle star level. Osaka rate: 18 tawara.

弐: 100 ryō committed. 20 tawara held at the middle star. At 一割 (10%). The manuscript notes 三万余世俵 (30,000+ tawara). Capital noted as 400 ryō.

参: At the middle star level. 弐割 (20%). 14 tawara per 100 ryō. Accumulated volume: 八万余 (80,000+).

四: At the middle star level. 弐割 (20%). Capital reaches approximately 800 ryō.

7.3.3 Scaling the Method: 200 to 1,000 Ryō

The manuscript repeats this same staged structure at four further capital levels (200, 300, 500, and 1,000 ryō). The pattern is constant: enter at 一割 (10%), add at 二割 (20%) confirmations, compound through the middle star level. The 1,000-ryō example introduces a fifth stage at 三割 (30%).

The following table summarizes the key figures at each level. "Initial" is the tawara position at the first stage entry; "Range" shows the tawara positions across all stages; "Target" is the effective capital exposure the method converges toward. Full stage-by-stage detail is in Appendix A (p. 45).

Capital	Stages	Initial tw.	Target	Notes
100 ryō	4	20	∼800 ryō	Detail in §7.3.2
200 ryō	4	14	∼800 ryō	Yield: 633 tw.
300 ryō	4	25	∼800 ryō	強氣 entry
500 ryō	4	15	∼800 ryō	
1,000 ryō	5	14	∼800 ryō	5-stage 顧氣

[5] *Translator's note:* The large tawara figures (三万余世俵, 30,000+; 八万余, 80,000+) likely represent cumulative trading volume across the full market cycle rather than a single position's size. The manuscript's accounting method is not fully transparent, and some figures in the cursive script are difficult to read with certainty. What follows presents the manuscript's figures as legible, without attempting to force them into a coherent modern accounting framework.

Regardless of starting capital, every example converges toward approximately 800 ryō in effective exposure. The key principle holds at every level: the larger the capital base, the more critical the staged method becomes.

7.3.4 The Method of Calculating Half-Board Rice Sales

半板売米諸勘定之仕法
Hanita Urimai Shokanjo no Shihō

The half-board (半板 (*hanita*)) method applies to selling positions. Within heaven's trading (天之商内), at the middle star level:

百両売 天之商内 — 100 ryō sell, within heaven's trading. Positions are calculated at 20 tawara entries. One sells at the middle star level, at 18 tawara initially. Then at 17 tawara—adjusting through stages. Selling at intervals of 500 to 800 bale positions, with the running total reaching the target through methodical staged exits.

At each selling stage, the same proportional discipline applies: sell a portion, observe the market's reaction, then sell further if the direction confirms. The buying price and selling price must be considered together—what matters is not any single trade but the cumulative result across the full cycle of entry and exit.

Chapter 8

The Seven Fortunes Secret; Following Gold

8.1 The Seven Conditions

七福即宝秘密
Shichifuku Sokuhō Himitsu — Seven Fortunes, Instant Treasure Secret

The seven fortunes are seven conditions that, when all present simultaneously, indicate a high-probability trade.[1] The trader must observe:

1. The seasonal cycle is favorable.
2. The price is at or below the middle star.
3. Market sentiment is bearish—the crowd is selling.
4. The harvest forecast supports the position.
5. The momentum of recent days confirms a reversal.
6. One's own capital is sufficient to hold through adversity.
7. The fortune-qi (運気 (*unki*)) of the year aligns.

When all seven align, buy with full conviction through the staged method. This is the "instant treasure" (即宝)—not that wealth comes instantly, but that the recognition of the opportunity must be instant and decisive.

8.2 On Patience and Money

There is a saying: "The money that was thought lost returns after three years." In trading, positions that seem like losses in the short term often prove profitable in the long term—if the fundamental analysis was correct. The error is not in the analysis but in the trader's inability to endure the interim.

[1] *Translator's note:* The source text presents these conditions as continuous prose rather than a numbered list. The seven-item enumeration below is editorially structured from the flowing text for clarity.

The cautious trader who holds stable reserves and trades with only a portion of his capital will survive all storms. He who trades with his entire fortune will eventually be ruined.

8.3 Following Gold

随金 商内 — *Zuikin Shōnai — Following Gold in Trading*

One's trading should follow where capital naturally flows. Do not fight the movement of gold—instead, observe where it concentrates and follow it there.[2]

Gold and goods move in opposite directions. When gold is plentiful and goods scarce, prices rise. When goods are plentiful and gold scarce, prices fall. This is obvious, yet in the heat of trading, men forget this fundamental law.

When one has entered a position and the market moves sideways for many days, doing nothing, the impulse to act grows unbearable. This is the critical test. The trader who exits from boredom or impatience will miss the eventual move.

[2] *Translator's note:* The distinction is subtle: "following gold" does not mean following the crowd's *opinion*. It means following the actual flow of *capital*. The crowd may say one thing while their money does another.

Chapter 9

The Grand Diagram

上割三下割之圖
Diagram of the Upper Three-Part and Lower Division

9.1 How to Read the Diagram

This diagram, which the source text calls the 中星圓珠秘象 ("Middle Star Round Jewel Secret Image"), is the visual synthesis of the entire trading system.[3]

9.1.1 Comprehensive Measurement (度諸)

For 700 ryō of capital at various configurations: the positions are mapped through buying and selling levels, with 300 ryō held in reserve. The ground of the trading terrain must be understood—positions are not merely numbers but represent one's relationship to the market's geography.

9.1.2 The Structure

The upper half represents the Yang months—spring and summer, the period of growth and rising. The lower half represents the Yin months—autumn and winter, harvest and falling. The diagram is oriented like a compass, with Heaven (天) and Earth (地) at the poles.

At each month's position: the expected tawara level, the indicated trading action, and the relationship to the middle star.

The subsidiary charts at the bottom divide the trading range into Yin and Yang zones. The Yin section (陰 八極) maps selling positions at supply levels of 25, 24, 22, and 21 tawara—representing conditions

[2] Bracketed values [24] and [17] are read directly from the diagram image but do not appear in the character-by-character transcription, which records only three values per side (25, 22, 21 and 14, 18, 19). The additional values are legible in the manuscript but were not captured in the transcription pass.

[3] *Translator's note:* The explanatory text for the diagram spans manuscript pages 28–29. The diagram itself is annotated 天明古写本 (*Tenmei-era source manuscript*), indicating it was copied from an earlier document and incorporated into this revised edition.

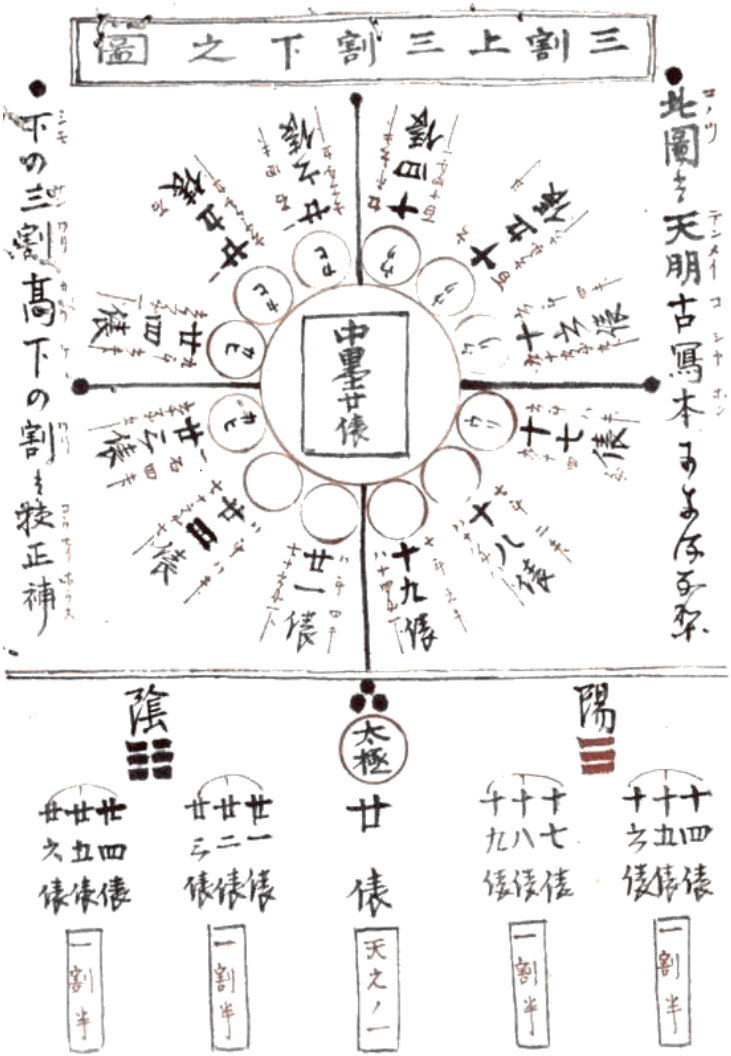

Figure 9.1: The Grand Diagram (上割三下割之圖). Center: 天明古米 (Tenmei-era old rice) with 中豊横 (middle-abundance horizontal) as the baseline. Twelve positions radiate outward representing the months. Bottom left: 陰 (Yin) with 八極 (Eight Poles)—selling positions at 25, [24], 22, 21 tawara levels. Bottom right: 陽三 (Yang)—buying positions at 14, [17], 18, 19 tawara levels.[2] Bottom annotation: 平の三割高下の割＝校正補 (“Three-part division of prices, high and low—revised supplement”). *Image: Kyoto University Main Library.*

of scarcity where prices are high. The Yang section (陽三) maps buying positions at 14, 17, 18, and 19 tawara—representing conditions of abundance where prices are low.

9.1.3 Applying the Diagram

In the four directions—representing the four seasons—combine the seasonal tendency with the harvest forecast. When buying in spring, confirm the middle star, then enter at the ten-percent level.

The rationale for buying and selling at each position is embedded in the diagram's structure: the monthly tawara level, read against the middle star and the Yin-Yang subsidiary tables, produces a specific trading action for any combination of season, supply level, and market momentum.

Chapter 10

Reading Strong and Weak Qi

10.1 The Beginning of Strong Qi

When strong qi first emerges, the signs are these: a ten-percent rise from the bottom. People are still bearish. News is still negative. Yet the price has stopped falling and begins to creep upward. This is the critical moment to begin buying.

10.2 The Beginning of Weak Qi

A small decline from a sustained high. People are still bullish. Good news continues. Yet the price stops rising and begins to soften. This is when selling should begin.

Just as strong qi begins silently amid pessimism, weak qi begins silently amid optimism. The symmetry is exact.

10.3 The Great First Decline

The first drop is sharp and frightening. Panic selling follows. But the first major drop is rarely the final bottom. After the panic subsides, a temporary recovery occurs. Then the slower, grinding decline continues to the true bottom.[1]

Patience is required to wait for the true bottom rather than buying the first panic.

10.4 Wind and Rain

When a storm comes and the ship is at sea, one cannot change the wind. But one can adjust the sails. Similarly, when market conditions shift suddenly, one cannot change the conditions, but one can adjust the position.

[1] *Translator's note:* This three-phase pattern—sharp drop, bounce, slow grind—closely resembles Dow Theory's description of bear market stages, formulated by Charles Dow roughly fifty years later in the 1890s–1900s.

The four seasons each bring their own storms: in the third month, late frost damages the seedlings. In the fourth month, the growing season begins and rainfall patterns must be watched. In the fifth month, the plum rains end; if they continue past this point, flooding is likely. In the sixth month, the critical growth period, the typhoon season begins.

The trader who anticipates these storms is rarely caught off guard.

Oil and silk prices follow similar patterns, and these observations apply to those markets as well.

Chapter 11

Regional Markets and Final Teachings

11.1 The Geography of Information

Each year, the initial rice trading (初取引 (*hatsu-akinai*)) establishes a base price level. From this level, observations are made month by month.

Osaka's Dōjima exchange is the central rice market; all other regional prices reference it.[1] Information from Osaka flows outward to the provinces, and the gap between Osaka and provincial prices creates trading opportunities. The trader in the provinces who knows the Osaka price has an advantage over one who knows only local prices.

Eastern provinces and western provinces have different harvest cycles. When eastern harvests are poor but western harvests are good, the price in Osaka reflects the average. The trader who can read the signs in the fields before the market knows has the greatest advantage.

11.2 The World's Accumulation (世の中積り之事)

When rice is expensive, all things become dear. When rice is cheap, the economy loosens. The lords (大名 (*daimyō*)) who depend on rice revenues are affected directly, and their spending in turn affects all markets.

In all the world's markets, the rice market is the foundation. What has been written in this record is the accumulated observation of generations—the secret teachings of the house, refined and corrected.

The market is not a place of chance but of pattern. Those who study the patterns—of seasons, of cycles, of human sentiment—can trade with the odds in their favor. But even the most learned trader will

[1] *Translator's note:* The text draws on records spanning the Tenmei era (1781–1789) backward through the Hōreki (1751–1764) and Meiwa (1764–1772) periods—roughly a century of market observation.

sometimes be wrong, and the method of staged entry and proportional trading exists precisely for this reason: to survive being wrong while maximizing the benefit of being right.

One should approach the market with the same virtues that govern all of life:

仁 — Benevolence: patience and compassion for one's own errors.

智 — Wisdom: study and observation before action.

勇 — Courage: acting decisively when the signs align.

節 — Discipline: following the method even when emotions urge otherwise.

The trader who embodies all four virtues will prosper across generations. The trader who relies on any one alone will eventually fail.

This record should not be shared carelessly. It represents a lifetime—indeed, many lifetimes—of observation, and its value lies not merely in the rules but in the understanding behind them. A rule without understanding is dangerous; understanding without discipline is useless.

To the reader who has studied this record thoroughly: may you trade with wisdom and prosper.[2]

鳴川猛之助
Narukawa Takenosuke
Editor and Corrector

嘉永四年五月廿日
20th day, 5th month, Kaei 4 (1851)

[2] *Translator's note:* The closing passages of the manuscript are written in dense cursive that is particularly difficult to read. The translation of this afterword may be close paraphrase rather than strictly word-for-word in places.

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Glossary of Key Terms

逢来 (*airai*)
Adverse conditions; a period of generally falling prices, typically lasting roughly three years within a twelve-to-thirteen-year cycle.

中星 (*chūboshi*)
Middle Star; the long-term average price level serving as the central reference for all trading decisions.

智 (*chi*)
Wisdom; the second of the four trading virtues. Study and observation before action.

帳合米 (*chōaimai*)
"Book rice"; forward contracts or futures on rice, as opposed to physical rice.

堂島 (*Dōjima*)
The Dōjima Rice Exchange in Osaka; the central marketplace for rice futures trading during the Edo period.

半板 (*hanita*)
"Half-board"; a method of calculating rice selling positions, as distinct from the buying-position method.

穂足 (*hosoku*)
"Spike-foot" or "ear of grain"; refers to the visual shape of price movements—an early form of pattern recognition.

仁 (*jin*)
Benevolence; the first of the four trading virtues. Patience and compassion for one's own position and errors.

人気 (*jinki*)
"People-qi"; market sentiment; the collective mood of traders.

禁判 (*kinban*)
"Forbidden judgment"; a cautionary ruling or prohibited trading practice, used as a marker in the Fifteen Articles section.

順来 (*junrai*)
Favorable conditions; a period of generally rising prices, typically lasting roughly ten years.

古米 (*komai*)
Old rice; rice from previous harvests.

両 (***ryō***)
The gold coin unit of the Edo period; the standard unit of capital.

新米 (***shinmai***)
New rice; freshly harvested rice.

節 (***setsu***)
Discipline; the fourth of the four trading virtues. Following the method even when emotions urge otherwise.

底 (***soko***)
Bottom or floor; the lowest point of the price range.

底直 (***soko-ne***)
Floor price; the actual price at the lowest point of the range, as distinct from the abstract concept of "bottom."

太極 (***taikyoku***)
Supreme Ultimate; the Neo-Confucian concept representing undifferentiated unity, here used for market equilibrium.

大勢 (***taisei***)
The grand trend; the overarching market direction.

俵 (***tawara*** / ***hyō***)
A bale of rice; the standard unit of measure and price quotation.

天井 (***tenjō***)
Ceiling; the top of the price range.

転換の法 (***tenkan no hō***)
"Turnover method"; the technique of building selling positions as buying positions reach their target, revolving from one side of the market to the other.

強気 (***tsuyoki***)
Strong qi; bullish sentiment or upward momentum.

運気 (***unki***)
Fortune-qi; the prevailing momentum of a given period.

弱気 (***yowaki***)
Weak qi; bearish sentiment or downward momentum.

勇 (***yū***)
Courage; the third of the four trading virtues. Acting decisively when the signs align.

随金 (***zuikin***)
"Following gold"; tracking actual capital flows rather than opinion.

About the Editor

Zach Booth is a software engineer at NASA Ames Research Center, where he uses AI systems—including Claude (Anthropic)—in his daily engineering workflow. Self-taught in Japanese since the age of eighteen and conversational in the language, he identified this manuscript in the Kyoto University Rare Materials Digital Archive and recognized that no accurate English translation existed.

He directed the translation using the same AI tools he works with professionally, separating transcription from translation, grading each iteration with an independent reviewer, and publishing the complete audit trail so that every editorial decision can be checked.

This is his first published translation. The complete source materials—original manuscript scans, character-by-character transcription with confidence levels, working translation files, and LaTeX source—are available at:
https://github.com/groverburger/sanen-kinsen-hiroku

Appendix A

Position Calculation Tables

The following sections reproduce the full stage-by-stage position calculations from the manuscript at each capital level. The source text presents these as flowing prose with embedded figures, not as formatted tables—the summary table in §7.3.3 is an editorial convenience for the reader, while this appendix preserves the manuscript's own format. These are presented as they appear in the source, without editorial interpolation. See the translator's note in §7.3 for an explanation of the units and methodology.

A.1 Trading with 200 Ryō (二百両買)

壱: 200 ryō committed. 14 tawara at the middle star. 一割 (10%). Position reaches 19 tawara.

弐: 100 ryō added. 14 tawara per 100 ryō. Accumulated position: 25 tawara at the middle star.

参: 100 ryō added. Running total: 19 tawara at the middle star.

四: Effective exposure: 800 ryō. Position squared at a profit, yielding approximately 六百三拾三俵 (633 tawara) in accumulated returns.

A.2 Trading with 300 Ryō (三百両買)

壱: 300 ryō committed. 25 tawara at the middle star. Strong position (強氣). 一割 (10%).

弐: 100 ryō added. 18 tawara per entry. Position builds through the middle star.

参: Position compounds. 弐割 (20%). 17 tawara.

四: Capital reaches approximately 800 ryō through the staged method. Middle star level maintained throughout.

A.3 Trading with 500 Ryō (五百両買)

壱: 100 ryō of the 500 committed initially. 15 tawara.

弐: 100 ryō added. 14 tawara at the middle star.

参: 100 ryō added. 弐割 (20%).

四: 14 tawara per stage at the middle star. Position reaches 800+ ryō, with positions of approximately 25 tawara.

A.4 Scaling to 1,000 Ryō (千両)

At the 1,000-ryō level, the text introduces a five-stage system with escalating price-movement triggers (顧氣—"reflecting on momentum"):

壱: 一割 (10%). 半年千両 (1,000 ryō over half a year). First entry: 100 ryō committed.

弐: 二割 (20%). 100 ryō added. Middle star maintained. 14 tawara.

参: 二割 (20%). 300 ryō committed. Position accumulates at the middle star.

四: 二割 (20%). Accumulated position: 14 tawara at full commitment. Capital noted at approximately 800 ryō.

五: 三割 (30%). The final stage—the full cycle is complete.

End of the Complete Volume

全 — *Zen*